process. The others present included advisors from Deutsche Bank, ABN AMRO Holding NV and NM Rothschild & Sons Limited. The whole process of the acquisition was very challenging, says Gandhi. It was the first time that an Indian organization was acquiring a listed company in the UK. The compliance requirements and the procedures to be followed were very exacting.

A secure line connected the two battle stations. Everyone knew that Ratan would take the final call. The auction norms required each suitor to 'raise bids by a minimum of five pence per share' and the Tata team had strategized to do precisely that until the last round of the auction. But CSN had also come prepared. It had a flair for springing surprises, or so it appeared. According to *The Times*, it 'twice tried to blow Tata out of the water by raising its offer more than once in the same round. But the strategy backfired. When CSN thought 566p would clinch it, after raising it from 563p, Tata came back with 568p'. CSN dug deeper and further raised it to 585p.

Gandhi and Ratan had evolved an interesting strategy. Although forty-five minutes were allocated for each bid, unlike CSN, Tata Steel waited until the last moment to make theirs. It was designed to give CSN the impression that Tata Steel was only authorized to raise their bid 5p per share at a time, says Gandhi. When the price had to be increased, a certificate had to be obtained from the investment bankers about the availability of funds. This had to be submitted to the takeover panel. When it was time for the last round, Gandhi and Ratan decided that it was time to unleash their surprise element. Gandhi got a much higher approval from the investment banker—something that CSN thought that the Tatas either would not or could not do. Their thinking was influenced by the pattern planned by Gandhi and Ratan.

When the eighth round ended, 595p was the base price. CSN increased it to 603p, expecting Tata Steel to increase theirs to 600p, as they had done in the earlier rounds. But Gandhi recalls that as discussed with Ratan, they kept their 'firepower to the last'. Gandhi had a final word with Ratan, and they decided to make their last bid. It was 12.01 a.m. in London. Gandhi 'stood at the PC and clicked the "send" button', dispatching the group's final bid. Before half an hour was over, he was on the phone with Ratan.

The time was 6 a.m. in Mumbai. Five hours after the process of bidding had started, Corus belonged to the Tatas. Tata Steel's bid had hit home. An